Canva Export Decision Card

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Which export for which job. Verified against Canva's Help Centre, 2 October 2026.

START HERE — WILL IT EVER BE PRINTED?

NO — read on a screen

`PDF Standard  (96 DPI)`

Flatten: OFF
Links stay clickable
ebooks, lead magnets, guides

YES — it goes on paper

`PDF Print  (300 DPI)`

Flatten: ON
Bleed + crop marks if trimming
planners, cards, KDP interiors

WHAT CANVA ACTUALLY SAYS

- PDF Standard is "for multi-page and text-heavy documents" — use it "if you intend to share your file through email".
- PDF Print is "for printing", and "the only file type that saves professional print quality at 300 DPI".
- Flattening "may increase file size, especially with high-resolution images or complex designs".
- Compress PDF reduces file size and is "available only to paid Canva accounts".

FLATTEN — WHAT IT COSTS YOU EITHER WAY

Flatten ON	Nobody can edit your file. Fonts are locked. Right for a pitch deck or anything printed.
Flatten OFF	Links keep working. Right for anything with a contents page — flattening turns pages into images and every link dies.

BEFORE YOU SHIP IT

- Open the EXPORTED file — not the Canva design — and click a contents link. This is the one people skip.
- Read a paragraph at 100% zoom. If you lean in, the type is too small.
- Shrink the cover to postage-stamp size. If the title is unreadable, it is not finished.
- Check the page count is what you think, and the filename is not "final version 2".
- Put a version and date on the last page, so you can tell buyers when you update it.

Sources: Canva Help Centre — "Choose the right download file type"; "Download designs as flattened PDF".